

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 105

Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1966-1974

Coverage Date: 1966-1974

Place Coverage

Kade area, Central Kalahari Game Reserve, Botswana

Section Title(S): Kinship And Marriage

Another aspect of the restrictions on behavior among the Central Kalahari San is seen in the distinction between so-called "joking relationships" and "avoidance relationships." Grandparents (*babam* and *masi*) and grandchildren (*n!odim* and *n!odisi*), separated from ego by one generation, enter into the joking category, while parents (*bam* and *gjei*) and children (*/wam* and */washa*), belonging to adjacent generations, fall into the avoidance category. Siblings are divided according to sex; for a male ego, his brothers (*kiyaxom* and *dabaxom*) are held in a joking relationship and his sisters (*kiyaxosi* and *dabaxosi*) in an avoidance relationship. A parent's opposite-sex siblings (those called by the terms for grandparents) and one's cross cousins (those called by the terms for grandchildren) are in the joking category, while a parent's same-sex siblings, being treated like one's parents,³ are in an avoidance relationship. Since parallel cousins correspond to siblings, they are naturally differentiated by sex. When marriage occurs among consanguineous kin, the spouse of a person takes the same place in the kinship system as that person (Figures 36, 37, and 38).

[593
Family Relationships](#)
[601
Kinship Terminology](#)
[602
Kin Relationships](#)
[603
Grandparents And
Grandchildren](#)
[605
Cousins](#)

People in a joking relationship behave very freely toward each other. They may talk freely, exchanging the most vulgar stories and jokes, or use each other's possessions without permission. Between people in an avoidance relationship, on the other hand, all actions require the utmost discretion, sex is a prohibited conversation topic, and borrowing the other's possessions requires prior permission. The relationship also functions within the marriage system: people in an avoidance relationship may not marry each other, and marriage between two such people is seen as incest. Within the joking category, particularly free relations hold between ego and ego's grandparents, same-sex siblings, opposite-sex cross cousins, and parents' opposite-sex siblings, to the extent that they may exchange gossip and criticism about

[581
Basis Of Marriage](#)
[602
Kin Relationships](#)

others, tell sexual stories, play pranks on each other, and so on. Possessions, even food, are frequently jointly owned, and the degree of tolerance between such people is remarkably high. They can be said to exhibit a very great amount of familistic solidarity. Since, as mentioned before, awareness of kinship extends only to close relatives, the joking and avoidance relationships also seldom extend beyond the bounds of kinship. The principle of alternating generations applies to these relationships, so that if A's parents, for example, have a joking relationship with B, then A and B should have an avoidance relationship. In practice, however, it is not possible to divide all of society precisely into two categories: if the San's society, with such a small population, adhered rigidly to the various structures on marriage and other social behavior, people would be almost unable to act at all and marriage choices would be limited in the  106 extreme. If potential marriage partners even among distant relations were limited too, the society could not survive. Furthermore, it sometimes happens that joking and avoidance relationships created by marriage conflict with the premarital state of affairs. As a result, these relationships are maintained most strongly among close relatives, weakening as kinship ties become more distant. This also means that the feeling of familistic solidarity decreases as kinship distance increases.

3. The parents' same-sex siblings are regarded as parents, but strictly speaking they are not called by the same terms. The element /u "in-law" is affixed, so that FaBr is called *ba/um* and MoSi is *gje/usi*.

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)